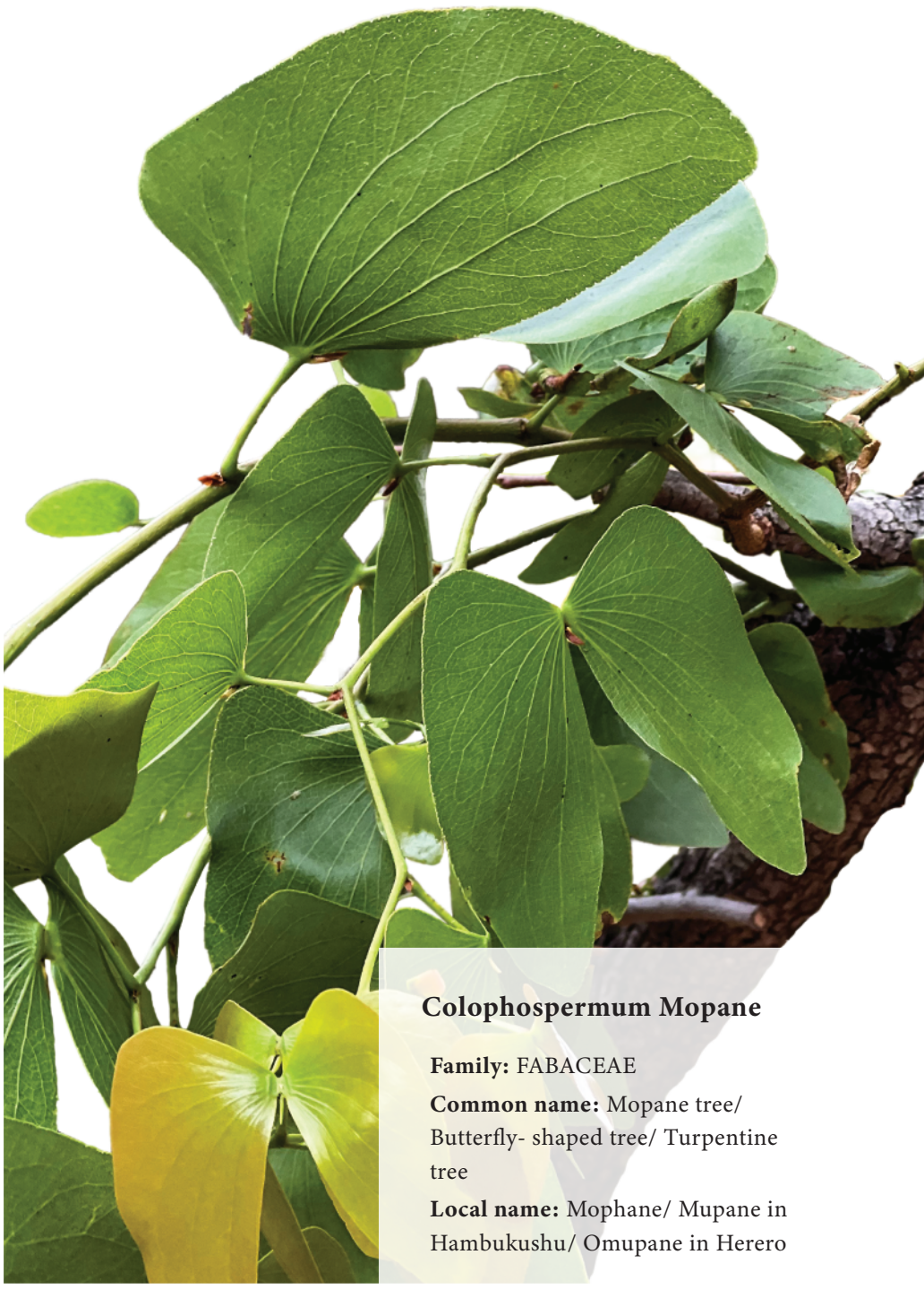
REPUBLIC OF BOTSWANA

MINISTRY OF ENVIRONMENT AND TOURISM

Plant of the Month November 2025

The Mighty Mophane Tree



Colophospermum Mopane

Family: FABACEAE

Common name: Mopane tree/ Butterfly- shaped tree/ Turpentine tree

Local name: Mophane/ Mupane in Hambukushu/ Omupane in Herero

DESCRIPTION

Colophospermum mopane, commonly known as the Mopane tree, is one of Southern Africa's most iconic and ecologically important tree species. Belonging to the legume family (Fabaceae), it is instantly recognizable by its distinctive butterfly-shaped leaves and remarkable ability to thrive in the hot, dry savannas of Botswana and beyond.

The Mopane's thick, leathery leaves are a testament to its adaptation to drought. Shaped like butterfly wings, the paired leaflets fold together during intense heat, reducing water loss through evaporation. The leaves which are bright green when in summer turn golden brown during autumn before dropping.

Its bark is dark and deeply fissured (cracked, split or furrowed), while the wood is dense, hard, and termite-resistant, making it one of the most durable timbers in Southern Africa. This strength has made it invaluable for construction, fencing, and traditional craftsmanship in rural communities.

Mopane trees produce small, yellowish-green flowers that attract a variety of pollinators between November and February. These are followed by distinctive twisted, leathery seed pods, often containing a single seed. The pods are food for wildlife, especially elephants, which also browse on the tree's leaves and branches.

Distribution and Habitat

Colophospermum mopane is widespread across Botswana, Namibia, Zimbabwe, and northern South Africa. In Botswana, it dominates large areas of Ngamiland, Chobe, and the Central District, thriving in alkaline, clay-rich soils that crack deeply in the dry season. Its distribution marks one of the most extensive woodland types in the region.

Ecological Importance

The Mopane tree plays a vital ecological role. Its leaves provide the exclusive food source for the Mopane worm (Imbrasia belina), a nutrient-rich caterpillar widely harvested for food and trade. Mopane woodlands also serve as important habitats for birds, insects, and mammals, maintaining biodiversity in regions where few other tree species can survive. The insects belonging to Psyllid group (Arytaina mopane) produce wax scales called ***"lerps"*** on the leaves that are eaten by people and animals.

Cultural and Practical Significance

In Setswana culture, the Mopane tree symbolizes resilience, endurance, and sustenance. Its wood provides shelter, its leaves support life, and its shade offers relief in the searing heat. Whether as a source of food, medicine (leaves and bark are used in traditional medicine for treating ailments such as stomach issues and wounds), or material(building homes, furniture, firewood and fences), Mopane remains deeply woven into both the ecological and cultural fabric of Botswana.

Fun Fact

The Mopane's common name ***"butterfly tree"*** refers to its distinctive leaves that resemble a butterfly in flight, a fitting symbol for transformation and resilience in the heart of Botswana's wild beauty.

NB: *Did you know there's a live Mopane tree specimen at the National botanical garden and many preserved specimens at the National Herbarium also at the Botanical Garden.*

OPENING HOURS
Monday to Friday 0730 - 1800hrs
Saturday and Sunday 0730 - 1800hrs
Public Holiday 0800 - 1800hrs

BOTSWANA national museum

national botanical garden

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